Navy beans give texture while rosemary and dried mushrooms provide loads of flavor for this rustic Italian-style soup.

rosemary's bean soup with italian cheese crisps

SERVES 4 **PREP** 10 MINS PLUS 20 MINS SOAKING **COOK** 15–20 MINS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT CHEESE CRISPS

½oz (12g) dried porcini mushrooms, covered in water to soak
1¾oz (50g) pecorino or Parmesan cheese, coarsely grated
1½ tsp very finely chopped rosemary
2 tbsp olive oil
1 onion, chopped
2 garlic cloves, chopped
3 rosemary sprigs
2 x 14oz (400g) cans navy (or flageolet) beans, drained and rinsed
2½ cups vegetable stock
extra virgin olive oil, for drizzling
ciabatta loaf cut into chunks, to serve

1 Preheat the oven to 400°F (200°C). Let the mushrooms soak for 20 minutes. Meanwhile, make the cheese crisps. Line a baking sheet with parchment paper. Scatter the cheese and half the rosemary in a thin, even layer on the sheet in an 7in (18cm) circle. Bake for 8 minutes or until it starts to turn golden around the edges. Remove and let cool and firm on the sheet. Strain the mushrooms (reserving the liquid) and coarsely chop.

2 Heat the oil in a large saucepan, add the onion, and soften for 4–5 minutes. Stir in the garlic, chopped mushrooms, and rosemary. Cook for 2–3 minutes. Add the beans, stock, and 6 tbsp of the reserved mushroom liquid. Simmer for 10 minutes. Remove the rosemary. Coarsely purée about three-quarters of the soup. Pour this back into the pan with the rest of the soup. Season to taste with salt and pepper, then warm through.

3 Break the cheese crisps into large pieces. For each serving, sprinkle with the rest of the chopped rosemary, drizzle with the oil, and accompany with the cheese crisps and ciabatta.